Jimmy and I are probably wired a little differently from 90 per cent of people. That doesn't make us better, merely better suited to our work. We can be prickly, but our success is linked to our bloody-mindedness. At the time, I didn't realize Jimmy cried at my final England game. I had to have a little giggle to myself, because that blunt Northern exterior hides a shy, reserved man.

He was there for me when he thought I needed quiet reassurance. He had my back when he believed it was unprotected. When I wanted to chat through a tactic or a problem, we would do so quietly, in the privacy of a hotel room. I wanted him by my side because I knew his intensity, like Stuart Broad's, reflected his singular purpose, winning games of cricket for England.

Everyone at that level is, to a greater or lesser degree, aware of their so-called brand, but Jimmy's authenticity as a bloke is unchallengeable. His honesty may be brutal, and his humour can be deadpan, but players who come into the England set-up having judged him prematurely on false assumptions are quickly converted to his cause. You see a different side to him as a teammate rather than an opponent.

Hesitant though I am to turn Test cricket into a travelogue, there is no doubt that climate plays its part in a player's development. Australia's outdoor lifestyle offers natural advantages. The hard, quick wickets in South Africa are educational. It is as difficult to think of a manic New Zealander as it is to envision a quiet day on tour in India.

Cricket acts as a release from the drudgery of everyday life across the subcontinent, but is not immune from economic influence. The lineage of the game in Sri Lanka, a small nation capable of producing great players like Kumar Sangakkara or Mahela Jayawardene, is being threatened by financial pressures that prompt promising players to play semi-pro club cricket in England or Australia rather than developing in the domestic system.

I've been fortunate in having responsive dressing rooms, so I am not known as a shouter, or a teacup thrower. I was at my most strident in Abu Dhabi in 2015, where it was as hot, and as humid, as Sri Lanka at its worst. That requires a three-day acclimatization period, but when training becomes a shambles because of the heat you have to act.

I got everyone in and let rip: 'All I've heard is how hot it is. It's unseasonably hot. What do you want me to do, turn the fucking sun down?